

Dhruva was marked by spotting an opportunity early in the day. Ironically, Dhruva's first stop was the UAE, known then as a tax haven. For Kanabar, the trigger was the UAE government's plan for a 5% value-added tax or VAT. The tax was a new concept in the UAE.

"Most people thought it was political chatter, but we decided to enter the market. If VAT did go through, it would put us in a strong position," recalls Kanabar. In India, Dhruva was then helping clients enter the world of GST.

The scenario then did not require UAE businesses to maintain proper accounts—auditing was not even on the horizon. VAT became a reality once corporate tax was introduced, and Dhruva's decision to set up an office was smart. Among Dhruva's clients in the UAE today are International Holding, Dubai Investments, ADQ, ENOC, Landmark and Majid Al Futtaim Group. "Our UAE office is one of the largest independent tax practices in the region with a workforce of 110 people. We are keen on entering Saudi Arabia, and with credibility in the GCC, we plan to build on that strong base," says Kanabar.

Talking from his Dubai office, Nimish Goel, Dhruva's Partner in the UAE, elaborates on how it is a multi-cultural market. "It takes time to get it right, but good work done for a large client helps spread the word. Once we get the little nuances, that understanding places us strongly in the region."

From the time Dhruva was conceived, Kanabar decided it would not be obsessed with targets. The tack was to build on its expertise and convince clients why they should be working with Dhruva.

Sandeep Bhalla, another Partner at Dhruva, says, "The one difference we bring is building a certain level

BIG DEALS

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Tax advisors on the demerger of the consumer mobile business of Tata Teleservices to Bharti Airtel



TIGREEN MOBILITY

Tax and restructuring advisors for the fund raise in the 3-wheeler EV engines business



INOX LEISURE

Tax and process advisor on the merger of Inox Leisure with PVR to create India's largest multiplex chain



SUN PHARMA

Tax advisors on IPR and related matters in the acquisition of Concert Pharma for \$576 million



EMBASSY REIT

Tax and structuring advisors for their acquisition of Embassy Tech Village SEZ for \$1.3 billion

| 83

of trust in the relationship, which could be with the client or regulator. Conversations with regulators are often more meaningful because we tell them what is right without bias."

Ultimately, it comes down to the scale and that gets even more possible with a larger clientele and also being in India at an interesting phase.

According to Mehul Bheda, another Partner at Dhruva, whatever is done has to work from every perspective—tax, the Companies Act, the Foreign Exchange Management Act, the Securities & Exchange Board of India, etc. "That is the key challenge and could impact even

a small transaction. One speaks of experience from a previous transaction, but the familiarity with a situation is most important," Bheda says. To him, the Dhruva brand is well-recognised, which, topped up with the India story, makes a difference.

Kanabar speaks of technology's role and how Dhruva has invested early and consistently. "Preserving the entrepreneurial culture is most important as we move to the next decade and beyond," he says. In a complex business scenario, only expertise makes a big difference. Dhruva has clearly understood that. **BT**

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